site to inspire confidence in the client company is not easily measurable, but sometimes it's all you have.

Table 1 lists six things toward which a requirements specification should aspire. It should only specify external behavior. Every requirement should be expressed as the answer to a "What?" question. It should specify constraints. These are best expressed as quantities: How many hits per day? Maximum page size? Maximum page depth? The requirements specification should allow you to change it later. While you should use **natural language**, do not write a long narrative. Number sections of the document and use diagrams where necessary. It should be a document that helps a future programmer learn about the system.

The requirements should pay attention to the entire life of the system. If the system needs to be able to recover from a catastrophic failure within an hour, write it into the specification. And the follow-up to this idea is that you should describe how the system deals with adversity—not just disaster, but also illegal user input. Some systems ignore user input that is not understood. How many times have you seen a "404 Document Not Found" error? It's nice when that page includes a link to the index page of the site.

Keeping these guidelines in mind, refer to Table 2, which outlines the structure of a requirements specification. The overview should be a page or less that reviews the goals of the site. If the goals were detailed in another document, make this document available. It is important to preserve the thought that went into the project at each phase. The requirements build on the goals, and in turn the design will build on the requirements. But being able to refer to the original goals of the system will be helpful to the designer and even the implementer.

Table 1. Properties of requirements specifications

Only specifies external system behavior
Specifies constraints on the implementation
Allows easy modification
Serves as a reference tool for system maintainers
Records forethought about the life cycle of the system
Characterizes acceptable responses to undesired events